Sons. Currently it focuses on four areas: ‘Aerostructures & Aero-Engines’, ‘Airborne Platforms & Systems’, ‘Defence & Security’ and ‘Land Mobility’. It was a very thoughtful initiative, said Krishna Kumar. Defence is a high-tech area, and Ratan was convinced that developing the sector capability would take India several notches higher in terms of attaining technical capability, explains Singh.

But Ratan was also fully aware, according to Singh, that as far as the private sector was concerned, its involvement in defence could be buffeted by the feast-or-famine cycle. In view of this, his primary focus was on plugging into the international supply chain. He had planned for TASL to survive on external orders until India was ready to source wares from indigenous companies.

TASL established its ‘manufacturing unit in Adibatla, on the outskirts of Hyderabad’, and ‘began functioning in March 2010’, with S. Ramadorai as its chairman. The company had already bagged several prestigious contracts and established ‘joint ventures with global aerospace majors’. In February 2008, TASL had inked an MoU with Israel Aerospace Industries, ‘Israel’s largest aerospace and defence company’, to set up a ‘joint venture in India for developing and manufacturing wide range of defence products’. Tata Sons’ reputation as an organization and Ratan’s personal standing assisted enormously in foreign companies reposing faith in the Indian company.

In June 2009, the company signed an agreement with US-based helicopter company Sikorsky (now owned by the Lockheed Martin Corporation), to establish a JV to manufacture Sikorsky S-92 helicopter cabins in India. The deal marked a ‘first for the manufacture of Sikorsky products in India’. Commenting on it, Ratan said, ‘We … believe that the manufacture of the S-92 cabin in India is a significant first step in the growth of India as a global hub for aerospace manufacturing.’

In July 2010, TASL established yet another JV with ‘US-based defence major’ and creators of the ‘legendary F-16 fighter jet’, Lockheed Martin, to manufacture ‘defence equipment and aircraft parts’. While TASL held a 74 per cent stake in the new venture, Tata Lockheed Martin Aerostructures Limited, the American company, held a 26 per cent stake through a subsidiary. The JV focused on the manufacture of centre wing box and empennage of military transport aircraft C-130J Super Hercules, now being inducted in the Indian military in increasing numbers.